SCAM DECODED · FREE CHECKLIST

The Scam-Proof Checklist

Make your family a hard target in one evening. Print it, tick it, stick it on the fridge.

1 Tonight: 10 minutes, $0

- [ ] **Freeze your credit** at Equifax, Experian and TransUnion. Free by law, doesn't change your score, blocks most new-account fraud. Save the three logins.
- [ ] **Pick a family safe word.** Say it out loud, don't text it. Anyone calling in a panic about money must say it.
- [ ] **Turn on alerts** for every transaction on every bank account and card.

2 This week: your phone and email

- [ ] **Carrier account PIN** plus number lock or port-out protection, so nobody can move your number to their phone.
- [ ] **Email first:** a long unique password and its strongest sign-in option (passkey or authenticator app).
- [ ] **Different password everywhere**, using a password manager. Start with bank, email and phone carrier.
- [ ] **Spam call filtering** on, in the phone's settings or your carrier's app.

3 The three rules

Call back

Urgent call about money? Hang up and call back on a number you look up yourself. Caller ID can be faked.

No strange payments

Nobody real asks for gift cards, wires, crypto, Bitcoin ATMs or payment apps to strangers.

No codes

Never read a one-time code to anyone who contacted you. Not "the bank", not "support".

Bonus: get a free IRS Identity Protection PIN at IRS.gov before tax season, and check your credit reports free at AnnualCreditReport.com.

4 Every scam has the same 3 tells

Rush | **Secrecy** | **A strange way to pay**

See two of the three? Stop. Hang up, close the tab, and check it yourself.

5 Spot these in seconds

- [ ] **"Unpaid toll" or "package on hold" text** with a link: check the real site or app yourself, forward the text to 7726.
- [ ] **"Your bank's fraud team"** asking you to move money to a "safe account": no real bank does that.
- [ ] **A pop-up with a phone number** saying your computer is infected: don't call, close the browser.
- [ ] **A job that pays you to like or rate things**, then asks you to "top up": real jobs never make you pay.
- [ ] **A check for too much** and a request to send back the difference: it will bounce, and you'll owe it.
- [ ] **A new online friend with crypto tips:** never invest through someone you've only met online.

6 If it happens: the first hour

1. Call your bank or card issuer on the number on your card. Ask them to stop the payment.
2. Call the gift card company or payment app if you used one.
3. Change passwords, email first, from a device the scammer never touched.
4. Freeze your credit if you shared personal details.
5. Report it at **ReportFraud.ftc.gov** (and **IdentityTheft.gov** if your identity was used).

Watch for the second scam: anyone offering to recover your money for a fee is very likely another scammer.

Want the whole family plan on paper? The Family Scam-Proofing Kit ($9, our own product) adds a scripted family meeting, freeze trackers for every family member, a 12-scam decoder, and a fridge card and wallet cards for parents.

General education, not legal or financial advice. Rules and contact details checked November 2026; confirm with the official source. Example scams are composites.